

ART BOOM

Hues of FAME

Art has moved from musty museums and dusty godowns to glitzy auctions and global galleries. Indian art, once a lowly recipient of state patronage, has become a feted part of society and an integral part of the emerging cultural arena.

■ By Atul Dodiya

If reformations are bloodless revolutions that usher in a new era, then I think Indian art is on the threshold of one. From Rabindranath Tagore to Amrita Sher-Gil, F.N. Souza to Satish Gujral, Indian artists have managed to invade the toniest bastions of high art which till now were the strongholds of European art masters.

Art is certainly not an easy creation. I remember when I was young, art was looked upon as a poor career choice. But I knew, ever since I was 11, that I wanted to be a painter. Strangely, my conviction stemmed from the time I was in Class VI when my teacher drew a boy kicking a football, and I stumbled upon the miracle of drawing when I replicated that picture. I joined the JJ School of Arts in Mumbai in 1977. I would often go to the Jehangir Art Gallery to see the work of artists like M.F. Husain and Syed Haider Raza. It was at this time that I met Akbar Padamse and Tyeb Mehta and as artists we would often discuss the philosophy and the art of creation. Funnily, even at that time, we never talked about the economics related to our art. Mehta painted in his bedroom and many of us were not that big at that time, but art was never a stepping stone to commercial success for us. The revolution for us in a way was in being artists and being appreciated.

When I reached Paris nine years later, art became something else. It became a microcosm for me where I saw the artists of the world converge in the vast and colourful painting that Paris was. It was

Rs 7 cr
was the price of
Tyeb Mehta's
Mahishasura, the
highest paid for
an Indian painting

